And if the answer to that question is, as Smt. Swaraj suggests, that it is the holiest book of the overwhelming Hindu majority of our population, the proposition is contestable, like most things in Hindu philosophy. As a practising (and reasonably widely-read) Hindu myself, I find many ideas in the *Upanishad*s and the *Purana*s that are not in the *Gita*. I see Hinduism as a pluralistic faith of many holy books and many ways of worshipping the Divine. You don't have to agree with those Hindu scholars who argue that the *Gita*, being part of an *itihasa*, a subset of *smriti* (that which is heard and remembered, orally), ranks lower in the hierarchy of Hindu sacred texts than the Vedas and the *Upanishad*s, which are *sruti* (seen, heard and recorded divine revelation). But such arguments apart, there is no doubt that there are many views of the relative merits of several Indian holy books.

Smt. Swaraj (like many before her, including Vivekananda and Gandhiji) may be inspired by the *Gita*, but other, equally devout, Hindus might have other preferences. As Dayanand might have asked: Why not the *Rig Veda*, for instance, the primordial revelatory text of the Hindu faith? Why not the *smriti* text known as the Srimad Bhagavatam, or Bhagavata Purana, which is recited for an entire week (*saptaham*) every year in many Hindu temples and homes? The quest to anoint a national holy book will not just divide Indians—it will divide Hindus as well.

But it's the fourth problem that's most relevant to a political discussion of the issue. For a government minister to raise the idea of a national holy book serves to ignite not just controversy, but fears—fears of a majoritarian project that will slowly but surely erode India's pluralist (officially secular) identity and replace it with an overtly Hindu one.

Signs of such inclinations have been accumulating since the BJP rode to power in May 2014. There has been the overt declaration by RSS leader Mohan Bhagwat that all Indians are Hindus,[15] and by implication that those who do not consider themselves Hindus aren't actually Indian, and don't belong here. There's the statement by a minister, Giriraj Singh, that those who don't vote for Modi should move to Pakistan,[16] and the one by another minister, Sadhvi Niranjana Jyoti, that people are either followers of Rama or bastards (*Ramzaade ya Haramzaade*). Neither of